BEFORE THE
STATE OF NEW YORK
PUBLIC SERVICE COMMISSION

In the Matter of

Consolidated Edison Company of New York, Inc.

25-E-0072 & 25-G-0073

May 30, 2025

Prepared Testimony of:

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I. INTRODUCTION AND QUALIFICATIONS

Q. Please state your name, employer, title, and business address.

A. My Name is Pooja Oberoi. I am employed as a Program Associate with the Utility Intervention Unit (UIU) of the New York State Department of State's Division of Consumer Protection. My business address is 123 William St., New York, NY 10038.

Q. Please briefly summarize your qualifications and professional experience.

A. I graduated from the University of Delhi, India, with a master's degree in commerce. I received a Master of Science degree in Accounting and Finance from Keller Graduate School of Management of DeVry University in New York. I am a Certified Public Accountant licensed in the State of New York. I joined UIU in March 2023. Previously, I was employed as a Utility Auditor 2 with the New York State Department of Public Service (DPS) from October 2016 to February 2023.

Q. Please briefly describe your current responsibilities

with UIU.

A. My responsibilities include analysis of accounts, records, documentation, policies and procedures of utilities that are regulated by the New York Public Service Commission (Commission). I perform comprehensive research and analysis of testimony and exhibits submitted by companies and using information from audits, Information Requests (IRs), testimony in other cases, prior Commission orders, statutes, publications, and other sources. Based on that analysis, I make recommendations to the Commission.

Q. Have you previously testified and/or been involved in negotiations before the Commission?

A. Yes, I submitted testimony before the Commission in Cases 23-G-0225 and 23-G-0226 (KeySpan Gas East Corp. d/b/a National Grid (KEDLI) and The Brooklyn Union Gas Company d/b/a National Grid NY (KEDNY)). I also submitted testimony in Case 24-G-0668 (Liberty (St. Lawrence) Gas Corp.).

Q. What is the purpose of this testimony?

A. The purpose of my testimony is to respond to Consolidated

Edison Company of New York's (Con Edison or the Company) proposals of the Customer Operations Panel related to an Arrears Management Program (AMP) and New York Power Authority (NYPA) Account Management.

Q. Have you prepared any exhibits to be filed with your testimony?

A. Yes, I am sponsoring Exhibit__(PO-1) that consists of the Company's responses to Information Requests (IRs), which I relied upon in preparing this testimony and Exhibit__(PO-2) which provides UIU's adjustment to AMP labor expense.

II. ARREARS MANAGEMENT PROGRAM

Q. Explain the Company's current processes and procedures related to arrears management.

A. On page 16 of the Customer Operations Panel testimony, the Company mentions the process related to arrears management includes a series of notifications to customers including letters, emails, phone calls, and field visits. Con Edison offers payment plans and payment extensions. The Company refers customers who may be income-eligible to social service agencies for

additional financial support. Con Edison also offers an Energy Affordability Program that provides discounts to low-income customers who participate in specified government assistance programs.

Q. What is the Company's proposal in relation to an AMP?

A. On page 18 of the Customers Operations Panel testimony, the Company states that it is requesting a staff increase to 383 full time equivalents (FTEs), which will include 337 Customer Field Representatives (CFRs), 150 of which will be provisional; 16 Customer Service Representatives (CSRs); 23 supervisors; 2 section managers; 1 senior specialist; and 4 additional management hires. Company plans to hire all 383 FTEs prior to RY1.

On page 19, the Company states that staffing estimates were made by looking at historical staffing levels and projecting the estimated arrears reduction per collector, alongside the anticipated impact of non-field activities.

Q. What is the Company's estimate for the cost of the AMP?

A. On page 20 of the Customer Operations Panel's testimony and on page 7 of Exhibit__(CO-03), the Company is

requesting an O&M increase of $26,770,000 beginning in Rate Year (RY)1, with an incremental decrease of $2,557,000 in RY2 and a further incremental decrease of $23,000 in RY3. The request for labor is $23.155 million and for non-labor is $3.615 million in RY1.

Q. Did the Company provide an update to their proposed AMP?

A. Yes, on page 6 of the Customer Operations Panel Update testimony, the Company updated the total number of CFRs and supervisors it is requesting and reduced the total O&M request related to digital outreach for arrears management.

Q. Please summarize the Company's updated AMP request.

A. The Company originally intended to hire 150 provisional CFRs. This number is now reduced by 100, to a total of 50 provisional CFRs. In addition, the Company will not hire five supervisors who would have supervised these 100 provisional CFRs but are no longer required. Non-labor expenses corresponding to these 100 provisional CFRs, such as supplies and uniforms, have also been reduced.

The Company has also reduced some of its request for

non-labor expenses associated with digital engagement via email program and a planned collections SMS text message program.

Q. Why did the Company reduce the number of FTEs requested?

A. The Company states on page 8 of the Customer Operations Panel Update testimony that the reduction in FTEs is due to better-than-expected reduction in arrears. The Company also mentioned that the arrears balance was $1.4 billion compared to initial forecast for February arrears of $1.65 billion.

Q. Please provide a detailed schedule of the forecasted FTEs by year and how it compares to the Company's initial filing.

A. The Company indicated on page 9 of the Customers Operations Panel Update testimony that as of April 2, 2025, it has hired 218 FTEs dedicated to collections activities: 208 CFRs and 10 management employees. The Company expects to hire an additional 29 CFRs, 16 CSRs, and 15 management employees by June 2025.

Q. Did the Company make any changes to its digital

engagement?

A. Yes, the Company states that due to better-than-expected arrears reduction efforts to date, the Company is adjusting its planned digital engagement efforts to reduce the volume of emails and texts sent to customers.

Q. Did the Company quantify the effect of their AMP update?

A. Yes. On page 10 of the Customer Operations Panel Update testimony, the Company's revised request for O&M increase is $19,670,000 in RY1, with an incremental increase of $43,000 in RY2 and an incremental decrease of $23,000 in RY3.

Q. What is your recommendation in relation to the proposed AMP?

A. I recommend the Commission reject the Company's request to hire an additional 29 CFRs, 16 CSRs, and 15 management employees. This recommendation will result in reduction of $5.2 million to the AMP budget. This is presented in Exhibit__(PO-2.)

The Company has already hired 218 FTEs dedicated to collections, and recent data shows better-than-expected performance in reducing arrears, with the

arrears balance lower than initially projected. Given this progress, the current staffing levels appear sufficient. Furthermore, the Company can optimize its existing resources by leveraging digital outreach tools—such as email and SMS engagement—in coordination with the staff already hired, to further improve arrears collection efficiency without incurring additional labor costs.

III. NYPA ACCOUNT MANAGEMENT

Q. What is the Company's proposal in relation to NYPA Account Management?

A. On page 37 of the Company's Customer Operations Panel's testimony, the Company proposes to establish a new group dedicated to addressing customer care inquiries from NYPA and its governmental customers, including the Department of Citywide Administrative Services (DCAS), the New York City Housing Authority (NYCHA), Westchester municipalities, the Port Authority of New York and New Jersey, the Office of General Services (OGS), and the Metropolitan Transit Authority (MTA) (together, NYPA customers).

Q. Why does the Company propose separate account management for NYPA customers?

A. On pages 38 of the Customer Operations Panel testimony, the Company states that NYPA customers have a variety of inquiries with varying levels of complexity, in addition to multiple avenues of communication with the Company. The Company currently handles these requests through different departments focused on each of these specific program areas, rather than providing one-stop service for NYPA customers.

Q. What are the current processes and procedures that the Company follows for handling inquiries from NYPA customers?

A. On page 40 of the Customer Operations Panel testimony, the Company states that currently, NYPA inquiries are handled through a Central Customer Group (CCG), the group of Senior Customer Service Representatives (SCSRs) responsible for managing corporate customer accounts, including NYPA accounts.

Q. What is the Company’s proposal for additional staffing and the total projected O&M changes for the three rate

years?

A. The Company requests a total of 15 FTEs dedicated to NYPA support, including 10 SCSRs, 2 Supervisors, 1 Project Specialist, 1 IT-focused System Specialist, and 1 Project Manager. The Company requests an O&M increase of $1,040,000 beginning in RY1, followed by an incremental increase of $1,040,000 in RY2 and no change in RY3.

Q. Do you agree with the Company’s proposal?

A. No, I do not agree with the Company's proposal to create a separate account management team for NYPA customers. NYPA-related inquiries are currently handled by the CCG. However, based on the Company’s response to IR DPS-21-547, it does not track the number of inquiries received from NYPA or its customers, nor does it track the number of instances in which CCG billing representatives are unable to resolve such inquiries. Additionally, the Company does not track the average time taken to resolve these inquiries.

The Company is presently managing NYPA-related matters and is adequately staffed to address all associated

requests. If any additional support is required, it should involve reallocating existing personnel and providing targeted training, rather than expanding the workforce.

Furthermore, as stated in the response to IR DPS-19-517, the Company has not conducted a Cost-Benefit Analysis to support its request for additional FTEs. Given the lack of data to justify the need and the absence of a cost-effectiveness evaluation, I recommend that the Commission reject the Company's proposal. This recommendation would result in a reduction of $1,040,000 in O&M costs for RY1.

Q. Does this conclude your direct testimony?

A. Yes.